India. Converting a broad Japanese footprint in India into a deep one has, therefore, always been a challenge.

The two countries may have long enjoyed very cordial relations, but it also tended to be one that was low on ambition and high in rhetoric. Where politics and security are concerned, a Japan that was firmly placed in an American alliance was not easy to engage in the past. It was itself reticent and its American connection only added a further sense of distance. Both situations are today being addressed and these efforts are already bearing initial fruit. Improving ease of doing business and specially responding to the requirements of Japanese companies has also yielded encouraging results. Putting instruments in place is only the first step towards creating significant outcomes. Similarly, much closer Indian relations with the US have made it a facilitator, rather than an obstacle to India-Japan ties. In fact, the ability of India, Japan and the US to work together in a trilateral framework has been one of the novel elements of the changing Asian political landscape.

From India’s viewpoint, close ties with Japan offer many benefits. To begin with, it takes India out of the South Asia box to which it has been confined since independence. It also moves it beyond South-East Asia, which is as far as the Look East policy took it. Only a partner in East Asia that encourages India to operate there and reciprocates by also maintaining a presence in the Indian Ocean makes Indo-Pacific a reality. While Japan is essential to that endeavour, others like South Korea can also have relevance. The role of the ASEAN and its individual member states as a bridge goes without saying.

Another aspect is the contemporary requirement to form loose working arrangements with convergent powers. Where Asia is concerned, this requires some countries to step forward and take on more responsibilities in areas like maritime security and connectivity building. There is, of course, the most direct benefit of the Japan relationship: its contribution to accelerate India’s growth. Convincing mainstream Japan that a larger and more capable Indian economy is not just a business opportunity but also a strategic advantage is therefore essential. The challenge is for the Indian